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Thinking, Toys and Technology: A Six-Part Series

Part 1, an Introduction: Do you guys ever think about determinism?

Prepare yourself; I'm starting with the big questions tonight. What does it mean to be "made in the image of God?" The question isn't big because it's original. This question is older than our conception of time, and most of us have asked ourselves some version of it. It leads me directly to another question: What does it mean that God then chose to make Godself in the image of man (this is the heart of the question of incarnation, right?)?

These questions, part of a whole field of study for Nerdy Theologians, sound like a bunch of theory and woo. On the other hand, art lights these questions up like fireworks. We chew on them through song (*Galileo* by Indigo Girls¹), through visual art (Jackson Pollock's fractals²), and through books and movies. Even vapid subject matter, buxom plastic dolls dressed in pink and representing a white feminist fantasy, holds the most complex matters of human meaning. "I only exist within the warmth of your gaze. Without it, I'm just another blond guy who can't do flips."³

I've spent the last semester learning about some of the major thought exercises around these questions and applying those exercises to technology. For example, we make and train AI

¹ Indigo Girls. "Galileo." *Rites of Passage*. 1992.

² Taylor, R., Micolich, A. & Jonas, D. "Fractal analysis of Pollock's drip paintings." *Nature* 399, 422 (1999). <https://doi.org/10.1038/20833>

³ *Barbie*. Directed by Greta Gerwig, Warner Bros. Pictures, 2023. 01:34:37.

in the image of us. What does that mean about us as creators? How does that change our relationship to our creator? Throughout the semester I've found myself understanding these concepts because I saw them played out in, of all things, *Barbie*.

The next six posts will talk about how I see these ideas playing out in *Barbie*. Barbie and Ken, in their mutual and separate journeys through the film, become Capital-I-Individuals and begin to understand themselves in the larger context of community, the "world outside," and the realm of the Unknowable Divine (God, whatever). They experience the pain and horror of thinking in a meat sack; they wrestle with morality and self-consciousness and determinism (did Barbie ever really have a choice?), and they leave us with really hard, unanswered questions.

Part 2: Do you guys ever think about despair?

I really don't want to start this series by quoting Heidegger because I fear that his name alone will shut out the people most likely to find this whole series useful. But here we are, so I'm gonna call him Martin.

Martin wrote an essay about technology⁴ in which he talks about technology as revelation. He doesn't mean it's an epiphanic revelation. Instead, he means that it reveals something about the frame through which we view the world. He calls that frame "standing reserve,"⁵ and he explains that, "Everywhere everything is ordered to stand by, to be immediately on hand, indeed to stand there just so that it may be on call."⁶ Said differently, technology reveals that we view our world, this creation, as a source and provider: from it we extract energy, minerals, and entertainment. Without any particular thought, we place ourselves at the center of meaning and being, expecting the arc of the universe to bend toward us with provision.

⁴Martin Heidegger, "The Question Concerning Technology." PDF provided in class.

⁵ Heidegger, p. 5.

⁶ Ibid.

Barbie opens with two frames. The first frame explicitly references technology and its impact on our understood reality by recreating the opening moments of *2001: A Space Odyssey*. The scene reveals the frame that dolls traditionally force(d) on to little girls: "The girls who played with them could only ever play at being mothers. Which can be fun, at least for a while anyway. Ask your mother."⁷ When Barbie arrives, the discontented girls, like the apes before them in *2001*, devolve into violence, destroying their dolls with astonishing rage given their apparent innocence. Barbie smiles beautifully throughout the carnage, and the scene gives way to a summary of all the possibilities that Barbie created for little girls everywhere.

Those possibilities give us the second frame. The narrator reveals Barbieland as the frame through which Barbie views herself and understands her existence: Barbie is standing reserve for the feminist ideal. Barbieland represents the creator's effort to name and break the frame that insists that little girls must only "become" mothers and caretakers. The narrator sums up the Barbieland frame saying, "Thanks to Barbie, all problems of feminism and equal rights have been solved. At least that's what the Barbies think."⁸ Barbieland and its structure, from the magical realism of the initial wake-up routine to its treatment of Ken, serve to frame Barbie's conception of herself as The Feminist Ideal and her conception of Barbieland as a new Eden.⁹

On the surface, Barbieland is an enchanted wonderland of realized, feminist ideals, but that enchantment conceals, both from the Barbies and from the audience, that its "reality" reflects the priorities and beliefs of the storytellers who create it: the Creator, the people playing with the Barbies, and Mattel.¹⁰

⁷ *Barbie*, 00:01:32.

⁸ *Barbie*, 00:03:32.

⁹ Author's note: My daughter pointed out the New Eden connection, and I just stared at her with my mouth open for a minute. Did not expect my 13-year-old to "get it" that clearly.

¹⁰ Author's note: Hold on to your britches here. This thought will come back around at the end of the series when we talk about Heidegger's enframing as a core principle underlying Sylvia Wynter's ideas about the binary structure that undergirds Western conceptions of what it means to be a person and human worthy of dignity.

Critically, Martin points out that the frame serves to conceal itself.¹¹ A well-made frame doesn't feel like an illusion. My job, my bills, and my hobbies feel real and important to who I perceive myself to be. In the same way, Barbie's pretend water, pretend breakfast, and careful float down to her perfect car feel like reality to her. The illusion does not feel like an illusion. If it did, it wouldn't be enchanted. The self-concealment of the frame also holds the danger of the frame: it feels good, and it feels real.

Because the enchantment's illusion derives from stories told by others,¹² we see the beginnings of that deeper reality breaking into Barbieland almost immediately. The breakthrough moments begin with the tiniest glimmers. When Barbie arrives at the beach, she's met with a chorus of "Hey Barbie" so repetitive and absurd that even she can't ignore it, the smile freezing on her face as her eyes move from person to person while they parrot "Hey Barbie" over and over.¹³ Martin (by way of a guy named Hölderlin) calls this breakthrough the "saving power" that grows within the danger.¹⁴

By "saving power," he means that while the frames through which we understand reality keep us from the possibility of something deeper and more real about our being (the danger), that reality breaks through the frame with the power to liberate us from illusion. That power is the possibility of a different revelation, one that does not demand order and usefulness to understand how the world goes about being the world.

Back inside the Barbieland frame, the narrator makes plain the standing reserve nature of every person in the film with her introduction of Ken. Where Barbie exists as standing reserve for the feminist ideal, Ken exists as standing reserve for Barbie. Both as a toy and as an entity,

¹¹Heidegger, p. 10.

¹²Illusions are by definition only a mask or a cover for a deeper reality.

¹³*Barbie*, 00:08:17.

¹⁴ Heidegger, p. 10.

Ken exists only as an accessory for Barbie. After the film introduces Barbie in every kind of role from trash collector to astronaut ("Yay Space!"),¹⁵ the film cuts to Ryan Gosling, his shirt open to reveal a six-pack,¹⁶ and the narrator says, "Barbie has a great day every day, but Ken only has a great day if Barbie looks at him."¹⁷ On the surface, this appears as an opportunity to laugh at Ken's expense, but even that opportunity reveals our standing-reserve enframing of our and their world. Ken's predicament is the logical endpoint of a reality that frames every person and thing by its usefulness.

Like most of us (with our job, spouse, or kid[s]), Ken understands on some level that his existence in Barbieland orbits the wrong planet. In the opening scenes and introductions, Ken embodies Kierkegaard's¹⁸ first form of despair.¹⁹ Ken is ostensibly a sentient, self-conscious soul, but he is not conscious that he has a self, only that he wants Barbie's attention. He even describes his vocation as "just beach,"²⁰ reflecting the incomplete nature of his self-conception.

Counter-intuitively, Barbie also suffers from the first form of despair. Together, Barbie and Ken reveal the fullness of the first form. In Ken we see the grief and misery of the despair that doesn't even know it is despair. In Barbie, we see the danger of this despair: it's comfortable.

With both main characters trapped in the despair of an enchanted life that stifles and even suffocates their nascent sense[s] of self, the frame that encodes the enchantment must break for the story to unfold AND for the characters to become selves. Ken initiates the first crack in his

¹⁵*Barbie*, 00:07:48.

¹⁶Author's note: This would be a wonderful place to jump off into a side-quest to explore Barbie as a reversal of Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex*, but I'm trying to limit my word count. Suffice to note that the film carefully reduces Ken to an object.

¹⁷Foreshadowing one of Ken's most famous lines: "I only exist within the light of your eyes." *Barbie*, 01:34:37.

¹⁸Author's note: I thought about using Kierkegaard's first name like I am Heidegger's, but I don't think Søren is any less jarring than Kierkegaard.

¹⁹The first form of despair is to be unaware that you have a self. It is to be ignorant of your own capacity for depth and self-knowledge and to be blissfully unaware of the fact that you are unaware. Kierkegaard presents this as a surface existence with no anchor and no hope.

Søren Kierkegaard, *The Sickness Unto Death*, trans. Bruce Kirmmse. New York: Liveright Publishing, 2023, p. 55.

²⁰ *Barbie*, 00:10:48.

bid for Barbie's attention, and into that crack, Gloria²¹ pours the ingredients (cellulite, irrepressible thoughts of death) that will force Barbie to act.

Which leads us to determinism. Did Barbie ever have a choice? If Heidegger's "saving power" always had to break in to Barbie's enframed reality, then was her journey pre-ordained? Is that pre-ordination then a kind of grace because it leads her (and Ken) to become a self? Weird Barbie insists on a deterministic outlook for Barbie, forcing her to take the Birkenstock over the high heel.

As "irrepressible thoughts of death" break through Barbie's reality and force her to question her comfortable despair, we see that what has been concealed by the standing reserve frame follows close on the heels of those thoughts.

Part 3: Do you guys ever think about disruption?

With regard to growing into oneSelf, Arendt writes about thinking and Kierkegaard writes about relating. How do they converge, and what does *Barbie* have to say about that?

Building on Martin's work about thinking, Hannah Arendt argues that "the most important point is to distinguish thinking from knowing."²² So let's start there. In Arendt's view, knowing is cognition, and it is tangible. We know a thing and that knowledge is usable. Remember that technology reveals that we experience ourselves and the world as "standing reserve?" Knowledge is the mental territory of standing reserve. Education, science, and experience produce knowledge, and we use that knowledge to manage our reality.

²¹Gloria is a human character we meet later in *Barbie* (2023).

²²Richard Bernstein, "Arendt on Thinking." In: Villa D, ed. *The Cambridge Companion to Hannah Arendt*. Cambridge Companions to Philosophy. Cambridge University Press; 2000:283.

Thinking, on the other hand, refuses to produce an end result. According to Arendt (well, according to Bernstein writing about Arendt), "Thinking is the faculty by which we ask unanswerable questions, but questions that we cannot help asking."²³

Meanwhile, Kierkegaard (who, to be fair, is a century before Arendt), addresses self as a relationship, and he insists that in order to know yourSelf, you must be conscious of yourSelf. Where the first form of despair is to be unconscious of the self, the second form of despair is to be conscious but not to want to develop or relate to your Self. This second despair is a more serious form because the sufferer has recognized their own Self as a possibility but withdraws and turns away from the possibility because it is scary.²⁴

Barbie's conversation with Weird Barbie beautifully illustrates both the disruptive, in-breaking nature of thinking that Arendt posits and the human compulsion to retreat from that disruption that Kierkegaard suggests with the second form of despair. Thoughts of death—Barbie's metaphor for the disruption of becoming—have broken in to Barbie's enchanted reality without her consent or will. After blurting out her question, "Do you guys ever think about dying?"²⁵ the record scratches, and Kierkegaard's crowd stares in gaping horror. Barbie's response demonstrates that the thoughts come without her control or her will: "I don't know why I just said that."²⁶ Barbie recovers, says something that reassures the crowd, and finishes the evening looking profoundly uncomfortable.

Over the course of the next morning's wake up, we see Barbie's thinking and self-consciousness become more and more intrusive, developing into what Arendt describes as "the

²³Bernstein 283. [Incomplete citation: see footnote 10]

²⁴Kierkegaard, 65.

²⁵*Barbie*, 00:13:36.

²⁶*Barbie*, 00:13:48.

two-in-one of the soundless dialogue"²⁷ we have within our own minds. Arendt connects the two-in-one to the development of consciousness and conscience. Lizzo's second "Pink" demonstrates Barbie's first experiences of this inner dialogue, commenting on Barbie's bad breath, cold shower, and soured milk.²⁸

When Barbie finally stands before Weird Barbie, confronted with the possibility that she "had something to do with this,"²⁹ she responds by retreating from the possibility, saying, "I've only ever wanted for everything to stay exactly as it is."³⁰ It's too late to go back, though. Death calls, and cellulite looms.

Meanwhile, Ken relies on knowing rather than thinking. Where Barbie has these unresolvable questions but does not want change, Ken wants change without engaging thought. Arendt examines this behavior in context of Nazism, specifically a Nazi named Adolf Eichmann, one of the major organizers of the holocaust. She concludes that his evil sprouted not from some demonic wellspring of darkness in his soul but from his complete unwillingness to think. She called this the "banality of evil"³¹ and argued that evil and immorality arise when the guardrails against these things are externalized³² and no longer originate from our active thinking.

Ken is no Nazi, to be sure. However, he demonstrates the danger of refusing thought with his whole-hearted embrace of patriarchy. He recognizes his discomfort in Barbieland, and he embraces the first thing that appears to address that discomfort. Eichmann is recorded as saying, "Now that I look back, I realize that a life predicated on being obedient and taking orders is a

²⁷Bernstein, 285.

²⁸Lizzo, "Pink." *Barbie: The Album*, Atlantic Records, 2023, track 1. *Spotify*.

²⁹*Barbie*, 00:21:57.

³⁰*Barbie*, 00:22:02.

³¹Hannah Arendt. *Eichmann in Jerusalem: A Report on the Banality of Evil*. Penguin Classics, 2006.

³²Author's note: Meaning that our agreements about virtue come from social rules and habits rather than from internalized thought patterns that recognize virtue as its own value.

very comfortable life indeed. Living in such a way reduces to a minimum one's need to think."³³

Along the same lines, in his "becoming" conversation with Barbie, Ken says, "To be honest, when I found out that patriarchy wasn't about horses, I lost interest anyway."³⁴ Ken latched on to patriarchy because it served him without requiring him to inquire or think in the same way that Eichmann embraced Nazism because it was easy to obey.

In a movie about dolls, targeted at children, Greta Gerwig confronts her audience with the banality of evil and the criticality of thinking as its remedy. Ken's embrace of patriarchy meets his "need" for external validation without requiring him to question why he wants the external validation in the first place. He has not challenged or thought about the fact that he is standing in reserve. He simply changes the thing for which he is reserved. In the first place, he's reserved for Barbie. In the second, he's reserved to lead the Kens in their rebellion.

How do thinking and knowing the Self relate to technology? That question invites us to examine our own relationship to technology. With toys and technology, we get to be creators that exist in unutterably greater complexity than that of our creation. We find ourselves locked between layers of the "Chain of Being," with a creator "above" us and our creations "below" us, providing yet another frame through which to consider what it means to be human. *Barbie* flirts with these questions in her interactions with the creator (Ruth Handler). Barbie is Handler's technology and creation, and the Barbies' reverence for their creator mimics how we revere our own.

These questions matter not because sentience is imminent or because of the Impending Robot Armageddon. They matter because how we choose to relate to our creations directly impacts how we choose to conceive of and relate to our Self. The frame we create is relatedness

³³Bernstein, 286.

³⁴*Barbie*, 01:33:32.

to Self and Other. I distinctly remember being twelve and feeling immense guilt because I carelessly tossed a teddy bear onto the floor. I remember my gut twisting and tears threatening behind my eyes because I didn't want to cause harm to anything. The value of that moment is not in my misplaced sentimentality about an inanimate object; rather, the value lies in my body's commitment to goodness and my subsequent choice, born of thought, to be good to things outside myself even when it doesn't seem to matter.

Part 4: Do you guys ever think about disorientation?

Barbie does a lot of philosophical work through drama and humor. The movie allows us to approach it through an entertainment lens, a theological lens, a humanist lens, and in this case, a philosophical lens. In our case, *Barbie* functions as a metaphor for technology because both the toy and the tech exist because humanity created them.

In my last post, I talked about my teddy bears and my grief at mistreating them as I grew older. We relate to our things just as fully—sometimes more so if we are honest—as we do to the other people in our lives. We all generally agree that neither the doll nor the device has an interior life, but rarely do we actually ask whether non-human creations could have one. The more important question though, is "Why should I care whether a non-human creation has an inner life?"

Let's summarize our understanding of the self so far.

First, Arendt's self has thinking (as opposed to knowing). All the Barbies clearly have cognition. They serve as politicians, astronauts, construction workers, and writers. In the same way, our technology clearly has cognitive processes. AI can take in and analyze a pdf of "*The Sickness Unto Death*" and tell me what it's all about. However, neither the Barbies (at the start of

the movie) nor our technology demonstrate Arendt's disruptive, disorienting, and intrusive thinking. The rest of the movie asks us to examine what happens after thinking happens.

Next, Kierkegaard tells us that the self has interiority and internal relatedness. My beloved Lima Bean will never forgive me or Dr. Vial for exposing him to this: "But what is self? The self is a relation that relates to itself, or it is that in the relation which is the relation's relating to itself."³⁵ Thinking intrudes, and it forces the thinker to consider the Self. "Do you guys ever think about dying? [Long, awkward pause] I don't know why I just said that."³⁶ Barbie's recognition that she said something without reason reflects that thinking has occurred uninvited, and like a virus, it takes hold and upends everything. The following morning, Barbie has already begun to develop the relatedness that Kierkegaard talks about in the form of Arendt's two-in-one internal dialogue in the voice of Lizzo.

This leap from cognition to thinking remains a mystery. What caused Barbie's first thoughts of death and "the rip in the continuum?"³⁷ The movie suggests Ken's discontent triggers the events, but why does Ken's discontent trigger Barbie's thinking but not his own? These questions apply, all of them, to technology. Throughout popular culture we ask again and again what happens when computers begin to think. *Barbie* itself calls back to one of the most well-known explorations of that question and how threatening and fearsome it can feel to humanity by opening with its *2001: A Space Odyssey*³⁸ sequence. Arendt notes specifically that thinking does not provide answers or resolution,³⁹ and thinking about this leap illustrates her point nicely.

³⁵Kierkegaard, p. 19.

³⁶*Barbie*, 00:13:36-50.

³⁷*Barbie*, 00:21:05.

³⁸Stanley Kubrick, dir., *2001: A Space Odyssey*. Metro-Goldwyn-Mayer, 1968.

³⁹ Bernstein, 283.

Neither we nor Barbie are done with the self, though. The third strand in the braid of the Self is Heidegger's insistence on openness to a different way of understanding reality. The "standing reserve" frame that technology reveals seems to be the only reality we can know. Trees exist as the potential of lumber. Ken exists in support of Barbie. Barbie exists as the possibility of the feminist ideal. Through this lens, the Barbies understand the Real World only as the place they have enabled to live freely. They understand themselves only as the best possible realization of feminism and equal rights.

Heidegger tells us that with the inbreaking of thought, we become open to other modes of reality. One where the forest exists for its own sake, and we enjoy it. A reality where the Real World and Barbieland are more inter-related and mutually dependent than either could have imagined. This transformation from thinking to experiencing a new reality opens the Self to begin the difficult work of becoming.

These three ideas of what it means to be a Self converge in a braid. Intrusive, destabilizing thought forces relatedness to an interior self. That relatedness reveals the frame through which we experience reality and allows us to consider new possibilities for reality. That revelation brings choice (liberation) and accountability (to ourselves and each other).

So why should we care about whether toys and tech have an inner life? The importance of the interior life rests not on the question of whether the object has it but whether we are willing to engage with the interior of the Other. Our treatment of our creations—whether Weird Barbies or stuffies or humans outside our immediate circle—creates the frame we place on ourselves. In examining Barbie's transition from cognition and function to thinking and being, we get to imagine a world where our other creations, our technology, experience the same transition and then to ask ourselves what we want that to look like. More on that in the next post.

Part 5: Do you guys ever think about discernment?

Our last post asked why we should we care whether toys and tech have an interior life. Answering that requires a different question: Where does moral action originate? We've asked this question for millennia. Technology does not drive the questions; rather, its potential reveals the questions we already have. Either no interior life or thinking exists, or interiority and thinking disrupt the comfortable life in favor of "the good life" (eudaemonia). Morality then becomes a function of these two ways of being.

Philosopher Luciano Floridi⁴⁰ makes the case in his article, "On the Morality of Artificial Agents,"⁴¹ that an agent—whether human or artificial—need only demonstrate interactivity, autonomy, and adaptability to qualify as a moral actor. By lowering the threshold for what constitutes moral activity, he demonstrates that almost any agent can behave in a moral (or immoral) way. But that method cleverly slices away all the difficult questions that are raised by the possibility of a moral agent without an interior life. Moreover, it transfers responsibility for moral judgment away from the actor and to an audience.

Asking the same question of *Barbie*, are her moral actions during her "awakening" due to her apparent autonomy, interactivity, and adaptability? Or does she make them because she has experienced intrusive, disruptive thinking, causing interior relatedness and revealing the frame in which she has been living?

Much of the Barbies' behaviors in the opening of *Barbie* might be felt as morally questionable by the audience. For example, Discontinued Barbie⁴² yells "FLAT FEET!" and makes retching noises even as Stereotypical Barbie demonstrates significant discomfort. Then all

⁴⁰Luciano Floridi, Founding Director of the Digital Ethics Center and Professor in the Cognitive Science Program at Yale University.

⁴¹Luciano Floridi. "On the Morality of Artificial Agents." PDF provided in class.

⁴²Emerald Fennell plays Discontinued Barbie.

the Barbies spend a few minutes gossiping and tearing down Weird Barbie, who is absent, with obvious glee.⁴³

No one argues that these behaviors are morally acceptable; however, no one would argue that the Barbies in question—unthinking and unconscious as they are at this point—can be held responsible or accountable for immoral behavior, either. The morality they demonstrate can only be measured in context of their standing reserve purpose: The Feminist Ideal.⁴⁴

Floridi reduces morality to an engineering problem and glibly dismisses the hard questions as "out of scope." By relegating morality to the observer's judgement, Floridi relativizes morality and ethics. In its most extreme application, "In those days there was no king in Israel; all the people did what was right in their own eyes."⁴⁵

The opposing option, that morality results from an interior life brought about by thinking, finds its champion in Schleiermacher's *Soliloquies*, Chapter II, "Soundings." Where Floridi seems to advocate an external standard for moral behavior, Schleiermacher insists that an internal experience of the self generates moral behavior. "To behold humanity within oneself ... is the only certain means of never straying from its sacred precincts. This vision is the intimate and necessary tie between conduct and the perception of truth."⁴⁶ Weird Barbie seems to exemplify this position when we meet her. Her encounter with the Other results in a self-awareness that allows her to see beyond the concealing frame to the Real World needs of the Barbies in her care.

⁴³Barbie, 00:17:45.

⁴⁴Author's note: And the Feminist Ideal, too, requires a certain kind of conformity that abhors the wrong bodily or intellectual presentation.

⁴⁵Judges 21:25, NRSVue.

⁴⁶Freidrich Schleiermacher. *Soliloquies*, H.L. Friess, trans. The Open Court Publishing Company:Chicago. 1926. 28.

Schleiermacher takes this a step further, indicating that only self-knowledge can produce the certainty that we behave morally. "The sublime revelation came from within; it was not produced by any code of ethics or system of philosophy. My long quest which neither this nor that would satisfy was crowned in one moment of insight; freedom dissolved my dark doubts by a single act."⁴⁷

I find it useful to examine Ken's growth arc through these lenses. By Floridi's standards, Ken has autonomy, interacts with others, and adapts to the circumstances he encounters; therefore, he has moral agency. However, his complete lack of interiority and self-knowledge, Schleiermacher's standards, render him incapable of making moral judgments. He never had a chance when faced with the seductive reassurance of Patriarchy. It seemed to address his discomfort, and he lacked the tools and self-recognition to ask whether the possibility set before him represented a morally acceptable solution.

So. Why should we care whether toys and tech have an interior life? I suggested in that post that the potential interior experience of "stuff" provides an opportunity for humans to demonstrate care in how we construct the "reality frame" in which we and the stuff operate(s). At a glance, the dichotomy of external vs. internal sourcing of morality seem to cover the possibilities for "Realness." But both sides of the binary are flawed. Floridi presumes to excise the complexity of unverifiable interiority along with the difficult truth that individuals interact with and change the frames and realities around them. Schleiermacher assumes that self-knowledge will bring certainty. A third way, one that brings us back to Arendt's disruption and points us to Kierkegaard's sourcing, exists, and we will look at that perplexity in part six. Maybe we will even answer that nagging question: Who cares, and why?

⁴⁷ Schleiermacher, 29.

Part 6: Distortion

That third way I mentioned last time will find Schleiermacher and Kierkegaard on opposing sides of the Ken Wars. Schleiermacher's—Jesus, why do these men have such intense names? I feel like I'm sneezing and choking at the same time saying his name. His first name is Friedrich, henceforth to be called Freddy.

Anyway, regarding Freddy's interior certainty, all of us believe we know ourselves, and all of us believe we act with moral correctness. One quick glance around at current events, ours or Freddy's, provides plenty of evidence that most of us are wrong about our supposed morality, however certain we may be. This disconnect between the impact of our actions and the certainty of our morality belies the complexity that undergirds the process of becoming.

Kierkegaard has a third form of despair: that of wanting to be a Self in defiance of its own source. The third form insists that it can be a Self without regard for its source. Kierkegaard posits that the source is God, and that grounding the Self in God leads to the alleviation of despair.⁴⁸ Despair III acts like a teenager trying to figure out who they are. That teenager grows up to be Freddy.

Arendt tells us that contrary to the certainty that Freddy derives from his self-knowledge, real thought will disorient and disrupt the thinker. Kierkegaard, too, would take issue with Freddy's certainty. In my mind, what Freddy describes is much like that third form of despair: the will to be himself without being connected, grounded to a source outside of his frame. Instead, Freddy anchors to humanity: "my love and friendship always have so high a source . . . orientated towards the individuality of other human beings."⁴⁹

⁴⁸ Kierkegaard, 88.

⁴⁹ Schleiermacher, 45.

Enter Sylvia Wynter,⁵⁰ who carefully demonstrates that we are formed by the frames.⁵¹ This formation poisons the *Thinking* well in which Freddy wants to ground himself. With Humanity as his source, Freddy shows us the danger of the third form of despair: that we will be unable to recognize and see through the frame set in place by the one(s) who made the frame.

Ken suffers from 3rd despair⁵² and enframed formation. In his desperation for external validation of his Selfness, Ken embraces Patriarchy. He does this not out of moral failure⁵³ but out of a misguided desire to ground himself inside his frame of reference for reality. Without identifying, interrogating, and working with a source from outside the frame, Ken could not see the concealment he wrestled with. Ken has misunderstood his source from the beginning. Remember how, "Ken only has a good day when Barbie looks at him?"⁵⁴ He understands himself as existing for Barbie. Patriarchy continued to keep Barbie as Ken's source; it simply forced her to give him the validation he thought he needed to be a Self.

Only after Barbie helps Ken understand that he is as much a creation of Ruth as she is can Ken begin the actual work of becoming. Ken must find his Source outside the trap of his frame. Given Wynter's assertion that the frame has formed our thinking structures, we find that the concealing frame, employed for disruptive thought, becomes revelatory, just as Martin insisted way back at the beginning of this mess. More plainly, the frame we place on others, because it is a function of our thought structure, reveals the frame that we place on ourselves. Perhaps Wynter's most powerful contribution to the quest to become a Self is her insistence that we must

⁵⁰Sylvia Wynter, "Unsettling the Coloniality of Being/Power/Truth/Freedom: Towards the Human, After Man, Its Overrepresentation—An Argument." *The New Centennial Review*, Volume 3, No. 3, Fall 2003. 257-337.

⁵¹Author's note: Take the time to read this one on your own to understand one of the core frames by which individuals and our society at large is formed.

⁵²Yes, I know we've had first and second despair, but what about 3rd despair?

⁵³Even though his actions are demonstrably immoral—I'm looking at you, Floridi.

⁵⁴*Barbie*, 00:08:01.

identify our Source and interrogate it. We must understand how our own frames are built and how they conceal and reveal what is real when the Self looks for it.

Which leads me again to "Who cares if AI or technology thinks, and why?" The toys and tech are and always have been a metaphor for creation that puts humans in the place of creator. The stories we tell and the frames we use to tuck in our dolls, swear at our Alexas, hug our teddies, and keep Weird Barbie in the splits reveal how we have constructed ourselves intellectually and morally.

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